

The DOs and DONTs of establishing tech startups



Dhruv Agarwala

Co-Founder and CEO, PropTiger tells you some of the fundamental DOs

 **Be different:** Be clear about why your business is different and what you can do differently from others. PropTiger.com, for instance, is an advisory firm which helps home buyers at every level of the home buying process right from searching for properties to registering their homes. This is the full stack of services only we offer.

 **Find the right investor:** A number of founders tend to accept investments from anyone and everyone. But before getting investors on board, it's important to talk to other founders of businesses they have invested in to get a sense of what working with them is like. It's also important to think about the time horizon for their exit and to also assess if they are in sync with the market and prospects of your business.

 **Raise money intelligently:** Raise as much as you would need and then spend strategically. And, what works in favor of technology-based startups is that they don't need much to build.

 **Find the right people:** It's very important to partner with people who complement your skills. However, avoid getting too many people on board, as it might become tough to find common vision. Above all, ensure that whoever you work with aligns with your values and your vision.

 **Be sure and flexible:** Be sure to constantly test your idea in the market and seek feedback. When the feedback suggests changes to the original hypothesis, do have the courage to modify it without compromising on the fundamental vision.

 **Meet everyone you hire:** This may sound outlandish but do make the effort of meeting everyone you plan to hire for your company. Don't make the mistake of outsourcing hiring to others.

 **Be creative:** Often, founders make the mistake of spending too much money to grow business. One doesn't need to spend a fortune. One needs to be creative about businesses and how they can solve problems of customers. There is no substitute for creativity.



Yosha Gupta

CEO & Founder, LafaLafa points out the DONTs

 **Don't be a perfectionist:** Waiting to launch the perfect product, will never happen. launch your MVP (Minimum viable product)

 **Don't launch too soon:** I know this sounds like Paul Graham's list now but I've actually seen it as I was with mobile payment startup PayMate 8 years ago and a lot of what we did is similar to Paytm and Mobikwik now but it was just ahead of its time as ecommerce hadn't taken off there was no smartphones while we were trying to do mobile payments using IVR and SMS which wasn't convenient for customers.

 **Don't take the technology lightly:** Not having a Tech Co-Founder, even with 10 years of Product background, it gets hard for me sometimes. It's quite unimaginable how people with no tech background think of launching tech startups without a tech co-founder

 **Don't underrate commitment as a trait:** While everyone talks about hiring good programmers and how one good programmer is better than five OK programmers, my experience has been that hiring the initial development team only based on skills is not always right. For the initial set of hires, commitment and resilience rank way higher on the scale than pure skills alone.

 **Don't ignore Opensource:** Spending too much development time in building features which might be available via open source or through other startups is counterproductive. Before building any features check if there are other startups which specialise in providing features as a SaaS product for e.g. At LafaLafa, we use Zopim for customer Chat, WebEngage for website engagement and feedback forms, Parse for app push notifications, MAT for app attribution tracking. Use companies like Targetting Mantra for recommendation engines instead of building your own.

 **Not documenting anything:** Well documented and commented code is extremely important, especially when new members join the team.